

DESIGNER

SCHIAPARELLI

Courageous and highly original, Italian-born Elsa Schiaparelli was one of the leading designers of the 1930s. Like her rival Coco Chanel, “Schiap” did not have any couture training, which seems to have made it easier for her to disregard sartorial conventions. Observing the trend towards sportswear while living in the US in the early 1920s, Schiaparelli started off with practical knitwear that already displayed her determination to inject humour into fashion. The sign outside her first establishment at 4 Rue de la Paix in Paris displayed *Pour le Sport* underneath her name, later to be joined by *Pour la Ville* and *Pour le Soir* – for the city and the evening.

Art and inventions

Schiaparelli was interested in art from a young age and published a selection of poetry as a teenager. She was not the only designer to work with artists but her collections seem to bear a more obvious trace of the influence of collaborators such as Jean Cocteau and Salvador Dali.

Like the surrealists, Schiaparelli enjoyed shaking up tradition and introduced fabric and other items into new and unexpected contexts: she used tweed for eveningwear, waterproofed taffeta for raincoats, and fashioned hats into the shape of shoes and lamb cutlets. Buttons brought out particular spurts of inventiveness, and they appeared in the shape of animals, such as fish and butterflies, as well as chessmen, lollipops, and even miniature trapeze artists.

Excited by anything new, Schiaparelli worked with enterprising fabric manufacturers such as Charles Colcombet and was happy to use synthetic textiles such as rayon and nylon, and even cellophane and Rhodophane, a transparent plastic. At the same time the designer had a long-standing working relation with Lesage, the

famous Paris embroidery firm dating back to the mid-19th century. Schiaparelli was one of the first fashion designers to realize the creative potential of zips, although, as she admitted, “King Button still reigned without fear at Schiap’s”, at least before World War I.

Stars of the stage and screen loved this mixture of practicality and flamboyance, and Schiaparelli counted Katherine Hepburn, Joan Crawford, Greta Garbo, and Marlene Dietrich among her clients, not forgetting Wallis Simpson, the future Duchess of Windsor.

Daring to be different

Schiaparelli delighted in wearing head-turning creations herself, remembering in her 1954 autobiography that before World War II, “People were not afraid of being different.” Her clients had to have a similar attitude. When tennis star Lily d’Alvarez appeared at the Wimbledon tournament in 1931 wearing a Schiaparelli divided skirt, there was a public outcry.

Schiaparelli’s signature colour was a shade of magenta which she called “shocking pink”, and in 1937 her perfume *Shocking* was packaged in a bottle shaped like the film star Mae West’s torso. Schiaparelli introduced themed collections and in the late 1930s was inspired by music, the circus, astrology, and even shopping. Her *Cash and Carry* collection for the spring of 1940 featured large pockets.

After World War II ended, the “hard chic” look of the 1930s was replaced by ultra-feminine styles, which did not suit Schiaparelli’s particular brand of creativity. While her star no longer shines as brightly as in her own lifetime, Schiaparelli’s irreverent take on fashion was later emulated by Moschino and Jean Paul Gaultier.

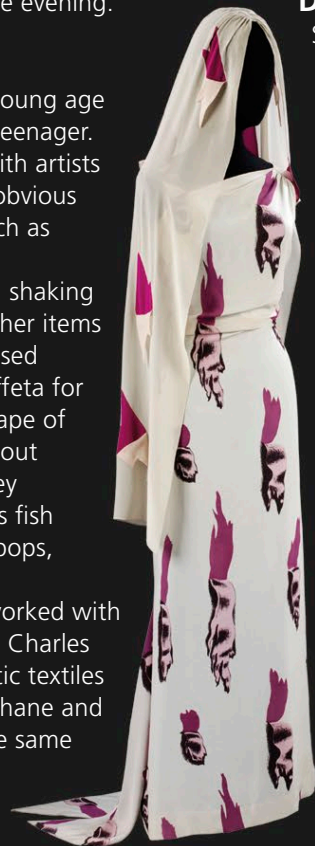


△ THE DIVIDED SKIRT, 1935

Schiaparelli models one of her own creations, a *jupe-culotte* (trouser-skirt), in London’s Hyde Park. Considered appropriate resort wear, this kind of garment probably raised eyebrows being paraded on city streets.

◁ THE TEARS DRESS

Designed in collaboration with Dali for the *Circus* Collection in 1938, the textile for this evening dress and matching veil was printed to look as if it was torn, apparently revealing the shocking pink lining.



TIMELINE

1890 Born in Rome into a conservative family of aristocrats and intellectuals

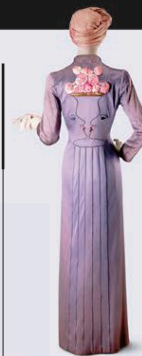
1913 En route to London, attends her first ball in Paris in a blue and orange ballgown she made herself

1919 Moves to New York where she mixes with an arty crowd including Man Ray, Marcel Duchamp, Francis Picabia, and his wife Gaby

1922 Returns to Paris where Poiret encourages her to design clothes

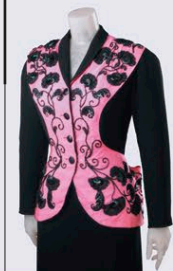
1932 Wears slim evening dress of white crêpe with red velvet bolero in Saint Moritz, further popularizing the short evening jacket

1927 Launches her first collection of handknit sweaters and opens her first shop at 4 Rue de la Paix a year later



▷ 1941 Moves to New York for duration of World War II. Returns to Paris in 1945 and continues to shock with new twists on evening wear

◁ 1935 Moves business to 21 Place Vendôme (the “Schiap Shop”). Collaborates with artists Salvador Dali, Alberto Giacometti, and, for this piece, Jean Cocteau



1954 Stops designing and publishes her autobiography *Shocking Life*

1973 Dies in Paris

○ 1890

○ 1920

○ 1930

○ 1970

◁ **A TOUCH OF THE UNUSUAL** This 1930s black crêpe dress with small turtles printed at the neckline was one purchased by Wallis Simpson. A striking black straw pole bonnet tops the outfit.